



CLOVER BULL-GEHLING, 9, shown with father Tim Gehling at a friend’s house, has felt crushing pressure, making it difficult to breathe, since the Eaton fire destroyed their home. The toll of the L.A.-area fires on children cannot be underestimated, experts say.

For little ones, fire is a lasting nightmare

Trauma can lead to meltdowns, regressions in child survivors. Experts have advice for parents.

BY JENNY GOLD

By the time the Fortier family heard the insistent pounding on the front door, the electricity at their Altadena home had been out for hours, and they were huddled around a flashlight doing a puzzle. Their neighbors shouted that they needed to leave — now.

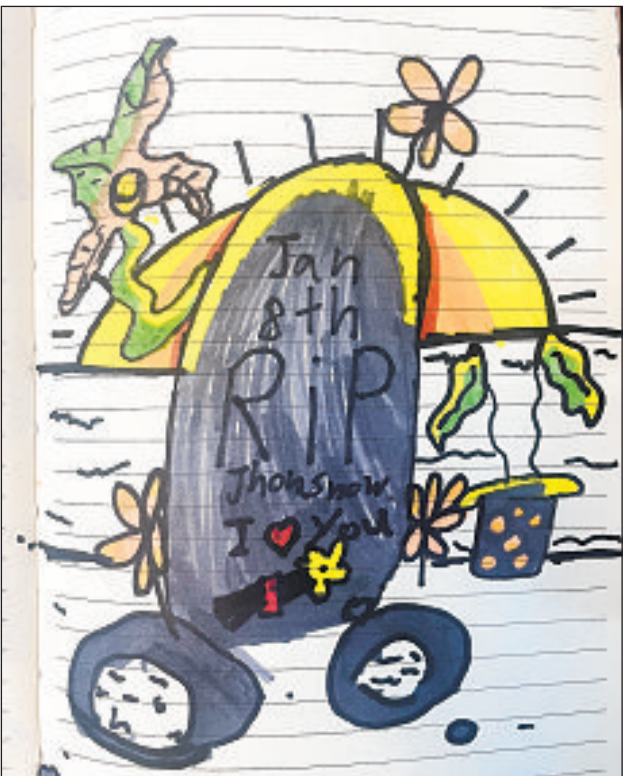
Graham Fortier and his wife buckled his two daughters, Abigail, 5, and Emilia, 3, into their car seats, while massive flames engulfed the mountain behind their home. Abigail requested music. As the family raced down the hill, branches and wind pummeling their car, the song “Best Day Ever” from the cartoon

“SuperKitties” blared over the speakers. Fortier hoped the music would distract them. It didn’t. The girls knew what was happening, “much more than you’d imagine,” he said.

Early the next morning, safe at a friend’s house in Burbank, the family learned that their home had burned to the ground. That day, the girls became “extra irritable,” melting down in frequent tantrums and clinging tightly to their parents.

“Both of them have lost pretty much everything they derived comfort from,” Fortier said.

While adult fire victims can be better equipped to process and act on stressful



COLETTE Liu Tervalon, 9, has been drawing picture after picture of her dog since he died in the Eaton fire.

COLUMN ONE

The journey to becoming a tall drink of water

BY BRITTNY MEJIA
REPORTING FROM LAS VEGAS

Late at night, on long drives around his Indiana hometown, Eli Mattern would ask God why he made the teenager the way he was.

The high schooler’s 5-foot-7 stature — 2 inches below the average man in America — consumed his thoughts. An ex-girlfriend told Mattern she was glad they were breaking up because he was short. He wore shoes to make him taller at prom last year. He grew so depressed over his height he became suicidal.

He lives among tall people, in a state that embraces its towering basketball players (e.g., Larry Bird, clocking in at 6 feet 9) and



ELI MATTERN, who underwent a leg-lengthening procedure in Las Vegas in December, rehabilitates last month in Wabash, Ind.

that was once home to the world’s tallest woman (Sandy Allen, 7 feet 7¼ inches).

“I just started getting really insecure and comparing myself with people around me,” recalled Mattern, a high school senior. “It really started getting into my head.”

And that’s how the 18-year-old ended up on a Las Vegas operating table in December, a chisel-like surgical tool called an osteotome wedged into his femur, as Dr. Kevin Debiparshad whacked it with a mallet.

This is the art of getting taller. Cost: Around \$100,000. Surgery. Pain. Months of recovery.

What might seem crazy to some — cosmetic leg lengthening — is a growing business for Debiparshad, Dr. D to patients and staff,

Making food safer won’t be cheap

BY KAREN KAPLAN

To hear Robert F. Kennedy Jr. tell it, making America healthy again means making American food healthy again.

The nation’s top health official says hundreds of additives should be removed from the U.S. food supply out of concern that they’re contributing to a rash of chronic health problems.

Plenty of Americans share his wariness. In a Gallup poll conducted in the summer, 28% of respondents said they had “not much” confidence in the federal government’s ability to ensure the food supply was safe, while 14% had “none at all.”

“Our food system as currently constituted is not designed to maximize health,” said Dr. James Krieger, executive director of Healthy

Food America.

Kennedy says it doesn’t have to be that way. And as the newly installed leader of the Department of Health and Human Services, he is in a prime position to change that.

But subjecting food additives to more scientific scrutiny won’t be cheap, experts warn. The added costs would present a hurdle at any time, but especially now

L.A. County considers a hiring freeze
Wildfires, sex abuse lawsuits and Trump are putting pressure on the \$45-billion budget. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

SXSW is back for off-kilter fun
Here are the buzziest features at this year’s festival in Austin. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Sunny and warmer. L.A. Basin: 65/43. **B6**

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‘Crypto reserve’ plan scrutinized
President says proposal would “elevate” digital assets. Critics see volatility. **BUSINESS, A9**

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In shift, Trump pauses some tariffs

President delays taxes imposed days earlier on certain Mexican and Canadian goods.

BY PATRICK J. McDONNELL
AND KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — The on-again, off-again threat of U.S. tariffs on goods from Mexico and Canada took another dizzying turn Thursday, when President Trump declared that Washington would temporarily reverse some of the sweeping taxes that he had imposed just two days earlier.

In a post on his social media site, Trump said he would pause for one month the imposition of 25% taxes on Mexican and Canadian imports that fall under the free trade accord — the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement — that he negotiated during his first term.

The tariffs — which Trump originally had vowed would go into effect as soon as he took office in January — were enacted Tuesday after twice passing previous deadlines.

Pascal Beltrán del Río, a columnist for Mexico’s Excelsior newspaper, compared Trump to the boy who cried wolf.

[See Tariffs, A4]

Newsom bucks his party on trans athletes

BY TARYN LUNA
AND PHIL WILLON

SACRAMENTO — California Gov. Gavin Newsom — an outspoken champion of LGBTQ+ rights since he was mayor of San Francisco — publicly criticized the “unfairness” of transgender athletes participating in women’s sports in his new podcast Thursday, splitting from his party on an issue that Republicans capitalized on in the presidential election.

The Democratic governor made the comments during the premiere episode of his new show, “This Is Gavin Newsom,” in which he sat down for a 70-minute conversation with conservative commentator Charlie Kirk, a loyal supporter of President Trump and right-wing opponent of same-sex marriage.

Kirk raised the issue of transgender athletes as one of many areas where Democrats were out of touch with most Americans and said it’s unfair to allow people born as biological men to compete against women.

“The issue of fairness is completely legit, so I completely align with you, and



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